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# George Masso

*George Masso was born in Cranston, Rhode Island on November 17, 1926. He played a number of instruments as a youth but was sold on the trombone after hearing Lou McGarity on a Benny Goodman recording. George's career has embraced the world of education and performing. He received a master's degree from Boston University and taught music for twenty years in public schools and at the University of Connecticut. In 1973, George took time off to tour with Benny Goodman, and with encouragement from Bobby Hackett, entered the jazz world full time. Since then he has performed and recorded with the World's Greatest Jazz Band, Woody Herman, Scott Hamilton and numerous others. He is a familiar presence at jazz festivals and parties across the country and he recently released "That Old Gang of Mine" on Arbors Records.*

*George was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 10, 1997, by Monk Rowe, director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and I'm pleased to have George Masso as my guest here in Aspen, Colorado, jazz trombonist and educator. And so, welcome.

GM: Thank you.

MR: You say you taught public school for eighteen years?

GM: Well public school for eleven years, and then seven years at the University of Connecticut, where I was doing most of the work at the high school, which at that time was a part of the Department of Education. I was Music Director there at the high school, E.O. Smith School to be specific, and I also was involved in teacher training for the university, the music ed majors.

MR: Did you have teacher aspirations as a high school student and so forth, or did you have professional music aspirations, or was it just a combination of both?

GM: It wasn't a combination of both. I really wanted to be a professional musician. I didn't think about education until I was in the service during World War II, and when I got back from the service I got married and began to raise a family, and actually a trombone teacher, John Coffey from Boston, was a wonderful friend and a great teacher, and took an interest in all of his students personally. It was John that said to me, you know, "Why don't you consider going into education, since you're raising a family?" I wanted to get into composition. But I took his advice, and once I got into it I had no regrets at all. I had many pleasant years in education.

MR: That's good to hear because sometimes teachers are often frustrated I think.

GM: It started out to be security. Let's do it for the security. But as I got involved I really enjoyed it.

MR: Do you ever see any of your former students?

GM: Yes I do. Occasionally they'll come up and make themselves known. They look a lot different today, but it's nice when they come and say hello, and reminisce about the fun they had in the high school band or whatever.

MR: So when you went on to the college level to do teacher training, you had already done the teaching at the high school level.

GM: Yes.

MR: Well that's really important, to be able to speak to it from first hand experience.

GM: I think it's very important and I was able to have the students from the university come over and watch what was going on at the high school, ask questions, and maybe give them ten or fifteen minutes to try to develop a little concept with the students.

MR: Your World War II experience? Were you able to play your music in the Army? Was it the Army?

GM: It was Army, and it was a marvelous experience. In retrospect it was a blessing that I did get into the service. I was inducted while the war was still going on. It was right after the Battle of the Bulge and they threw a lot of us right in the infantry. But by the time I had finished, in fact I was home on leave from infantry basic and the war ended. So I did get shipped overseas, but everything was so loose at that time, and they wanted musicians. I got into a marvelous "band" they called it, but it was an orchestra. It was called a Special Service Band of Europe. Tony Bennett was one of the singers.

MR: I had heard that. That's interesting.

GM: Jack Elliot was one of the arrangers and one of my roommates. Charles Heekin, a wonderful composer today, and Red Mitchell, a very well known bassist, was in that outfit shortly after I was there. But the point that I'm trying to make is that I became the staff arranger in that band with a full string section and all that. And that was my laboratory. No pressure, just write. The Warrant Officer, Lynn Harrison, was marvelous. He would just encourage, make a few little corrections, and it was a great time.

MR: Did you get a list of — would he say, here is your assignment: I need an arrangement of "It Had To Be You," or, we need more dance arrangements? How did that work?

GM: We would meet. There were three arrangers at the time. And we'd have a meeting with our warrant officer, and we'd tell him what we'd like to do. And if it fit in, and most of the time it did, he would just say go ahead.

MR: Wow.

GM: Yeah. 'Cause there was a lot of tunes that I really enjoyed and I wanted to put on paper.

MR: Did you have to do the copying and all that yourself?

GM: No.

MR: No?

GM: As a matter of fact, and Tony Bennett will admit to this. He was a librarian. He used to come down and pick up the scores from me, take them to the copyist — we had a copyist and that's all he did for the band. Our job was to perform once a week over the Armed Forces Network for the troops. We put on an hour broadcast. And all week long we rehearsed for that.

MR: Did you do live performances also?

GM: They were all live performances.

MR: I meant, actually what I meant was with an audience, a dance?

GM: Yes there was an audience all the time. It was held in the Wiesbaden Opera House, in Wiesbaden, Germany. And there was an audience every Sunday.

MR: How is it with the German population? How did they, I mean I assume you'd get out around the town a little bit.

GM: Not in those days, Monk. No. In fact I spent practically all of my time just writing. I was so engrossed in it, and it was such a great opportunity. I just loved it. So we didn't really get out, at that time, and get a feel of what was going on with the German people. Later on, I've done several tours in Germany in the last fifteen years, and that has given me a good feel of what it's like on the other side, and how they feel about jazz, and actually performing with some of them.

MR: Well we'll talk about that a little down the road. So in your public education, after the war, it was band, ensemble, and did you do brass lessons?

GM: Actually it was classroom teaching too, which I enjoyed very much. In fact I think if I had it to do over again, I would do almost exclusively classroom teaching and working with the lay people so to speak, those who are not involved in band, orchestra and so forth. Talk about music, and give them some background and reason for listening, and to try to develop active listening. Get them involved. I did have some very nice moments doing that, from junior high school right through high school, but I think if I had it to do over again I'd do it to a greater extent. Because I think there's a need for that.

MR: Boy, I do too, and we need future audiences.

GM: To put it very bluntly, you know, to develop consumers that can go to concerts. I mean I'd encourage them to build libraries of CDs and whatever, and books, and go to concerts, with some background, and be able to evaluate what's going on.

MR: We seem to be somewhat saturated with media and music is everywhere, and I wonder sometimes if it makes it not quite as valuable.

GM: I think you're right and you know, it's music to do something by. You get in the elevator they've got elevator music, supermarket music, they've got all kinds of background music. And people really aren't listening.

MR: We've learned to not listen.

GM: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Well you were convinced to come out of education into performing. I think I read this.

GM: This is a great story I think. Bobby Hackett was a good friend and he was a friend of my dad's. My father was a trumpet player, a professional trumpet player. And when I started playing, Bobby was from Providence originally, and I grew up in the Providence area. When Bobby would come into town, they would have me play with them sometimes, lots of times, just Bobby and I and a rhythm section. And at that time I was teaching school, I was raising four children, I was very much into the education bit. And Bobby would always say to me, "Maestro, when are you going to give up all that security and come out and scuffle with the rest of us?" And he got me to do it. He got me to take a leave of absence for one week one time.

MR: For one week?

GM: Just get away for a week, and go to Raleigh, North Carolina with him and play with a quintet. It was so good that I put in for a year's leave of absence. I got it. Through Bobby's help, I went with the Benny Goodman Sextet, and then later on with the World's Greatest Jazz Band, and I just never went back to teaching because it was a whole new career development.

MR: You were at the college then?

GM: At the University of Connecticut then, yes.

MR: Who else was in the Goodman Sextet at that time?

GM: Al Klink, Bucky Pizzarelli, John Bunch, Slam Stewart, various drummers, numerous drummers, Joe Corsello was one of them, and oh God, Mousey Alexander sometimes, and Connie Kay. Benny went through drummers like — going out of style.

MR: Yeah? He was pretty particular about that wasn't he?

GM: He was, yeah.

MR: Wasn't Al Klink — was he one of the fellows with the Goodman orchestra — no, I mean Glenn Miller?

GM: Yes. Virtually I don't think he was really a charter member. I mean he was with the group early on when then just began to be so successful, and in those busy years when they were doing the Paramount Theater in New York and the Chesterfield Show and the Pennsylvania Hotel, and some of them simultaneously. They'd finish a broadcast and there'd be cabs lined up waiting to take them to the Pennsylvania Hotel so they could

play a show. Yeah, Al became a very close friend. He's on the first three LPs I ever made.

MR: He's probably one of the guys that did one of those famous tenor solos on "In The Mood."

GM: Yeah.

MR: That's probably him, right?

GM: Yeah, that's Al. That's the only solo I think he ever recorded in the Glenn Miller band.

MR: No kidding.

GM: Tex of course was the soloist, and he was the personality that Glenn Miller was trying to develop, and he did so successfully. But he and Al were very close friends.

MR: I've always wondered sometimes, those solos from the Miller recordings, if they were improvised at the time. Because they became like THE solo to play. They actually would write them out, they were written out in the arrangements.

GM: I suppose later on they were, but I think at the time, when they knew they were going to make a record of a particular tune, and they had a solo, they would work out a solo, play it on the record, and maybe play it from then on, which I don't think is all that bad really. I mean if it was good enough to play on the record, why not play it a few times more? I mean I don't think it would be good to do it year on end, in fact I think that's why Artie Shaw got out of the business. Because how many times can I play that chorus on "Stardust" and mean it? I mean I'm not quoting anybody, I'm just — I think.

MR: Bobby Hackett — didn't he play that beautiful solo on "String of Pearls" was it?

GM: He played that beautiful solo and he told me he said, "George," he said, "I got so tired of playing that solo. I'd play it upside down, I'd try to play it sideways, try to play it backwards."

MR: It's a good solo, though.

GM: Isn't it a great solo? It's a classic.

MR: It is. It's like how could you play something better than that?

GM: You can't improve on it I don't think.

MR: Well so you went from — well how was Benny to work for for you? I mean we hear an awful lot of stories about him.

GM: Benny was strange, and the stories that you hear, I guess most of them are true. I never had any confrontations with Benny. I'm glad about that. I saw some insensitive things and they were done to everybody so it wasn't a personal thing. And yet it was a great experience because it was very challenging. When you got up on the bandstand with the sextet, you never knew when you were going to play a solo, you know, in context. He'd select a tune and then he'd play a couple of choruses, and look, and eye contact was how you knew when you played. You didn't know IF you were going to play a solo on that

tune, and WHEN, and when you did you didn't know if you were going to be able to play a second chorus and a third chorus, or if you were just going to be limited to one. So what you had to do was try to say something meaningful in one chorus, and leave a little room so that you'd get a second chorus.

MR: If you got a second one you hadn't blown everything.

GM: Yeah, exactly.

MR: When the second chorus was about to happen, was it a listening thing?

GM: Eye contact again.

MR: Oh. So you had to kind of look over to—

GM: You know you'd just kind of look over, and Benny nodded or he'd give you the — whatever.

MR: That's cool. How did The World's Greatest Jazz Band come about?

GM: Through Bobby Hackett. Vic Dickinson had been with the band and he took a leave and Benny Morton was filling in for Vic for a while, but I guess they didn't know whether Benny was going to be a permanent member or not, and Bobby Hackett did say some nice things on my behalf, and Bob Haggart called me one time to do a date with them, and after that I joined the band and that was a marvelous experience.

MR: There was quite a — gee you had, what four, five horns, I mean wind instruments?

GM: Yeah there were two trumpets, two trombones, two reed instruments, that's six in the front line.

MR: So was the music arranged at all?

GM: A lot of it was arranged, but a lot of it we didn't use. I mean they arranged it for recording purposes, and sometimes I guess if it was expected, they would put up some arrangements on a concert and we would play them. But for the most part, Yank didn't like to do that. I mean it was done, it was recorded and it was done, and he just felt there was much more freedom and flexibility in picking a tune and having everybody — you know it was such a nice experience because in ensemble playing, everybody had a certain place where they fit you know. And Yank knew how to make a statement as the lead trumpet player and leave space, and it seems like everyone else knew how not to over fill that space. It was as much fun, really, as playing the solos.

MR: Wow. What about, was it tough financially to keep that kind of size group together at these times? This was what, the mid-70s?

GM: '75 I guess when I joined them. '75 or '76. And it was waning then. It was pretty good, I mean they did pretty well for a couple of years and then it just got a little bit more sparse. And I don't think they cared. Because Yank was getting up in years and they had, you know, they were both great musicians and I think so much of a nice thing is fine, and then you want to go off in different directions. And they cut down the band eventually to just

the three horns, sometimes the four horn front line. And no reading, just picking tunes. In fact, later on we did some recording under the name of the Legendary Lawson-Haggart Jazz Band. Remember the old Lawson-Haggart records on Decca?

MR: Yeah.

GM: Well they revived that name and they called it the Legendary Lawson-Haggart Jazz Band. And we did some recording for Jazzology and Audiophile.

MR: I'm going to pause here for a second. Do you smell that?
[fly on light]

GM: Did you say you play at the university sometimes?

MR: Well Hamilton actually has a small music department. I'm part time at the college. I teach saxophone there. But I also work in a program called Arts In Education. It's an interesting program that — there's about 16 institutes around the country. It started at Lincoln Center and it's a way of teaching through the arts. We bring performances into the schools in all different disciplines — dance and music and drama and visual arts. But the teachers that are involved in this thing use the performance as a basis of a unit of study we call it, so that it's not just the idea of bringing the whole school down to the auditorium, having them watch something and tell them to be quiet because we think it's good for them. That that kind of doesn't have the effect that we're after. What we do is we have teaching artists, which I am one of, and we visit the schools and work out this whole plan with the teachers, of how to get the kids into the performance, and so that it's not just — they use it in a lot of different ways. If it's a Renaissance music ensemble, for instance, that they're going to see the teachers use it to help them study about medieval Europe, Renaissance history, about things people wore at the time, the social mores of that era. All kinds of things. It's really interesting.

GM: Like an interdisciplinary thing.

MR: It sure is, yeah.

GM: I was involved in something like that at the University of Connecticut too at the high school. The only thing that bothered me about it was it was just for a certain, select group of students. But they were good students and they were highly motivated. In fact I used to be able to get tickets for them to subscription series, and we knew exactly what they were going to be performing so we could discuss it before they went into the performance.

MR: It's important, yeah.

GM: And then we would take a whole period the following Monday and discuss it.

MR: Right.

GM: Not everybody had to like it.

MR: That's true.

GM: But I'd like to know why not.

MR: That's exactly. Like I'm not here to tell you you have to like this. But be able to discern why.

GM: Exactly. This is why, you know like the old suite says, you get too soon old and too late smart. If I had it to do over again I think I'd want to do more of that.
[off camera: I think it burnt itself off]

MR: Are we still rolling? All right. So after The World's Greatest Jazz Band, which I assume by the way while you were playing with this you were able to still feed your four children?

GM: Yes. Things got a little better every year. I eventually moved to New York so I was able to do work in the City. It took a while to establish myself, but I did all kinds of work there, Monk, I did society work, which I really can't put down, I mean if it's done well, why not do it?

MR: Is this like Lester Lanin?

GM: Exactly. That's who I worked for. I worked for Lester Lanin, I worked for Peter Duchin, I worked for the Meyer Davis office, and you know, first of all it paid very well and secondly the quality of musicianship in those groups is very high. And I'm a song player anyway. I grew up playing that kind of music with my dad, who had a band. And it's very challenging when you get with the right people, playing harmony lines on a lot of those show tunes. There's a formula that's used. You know, the trombone player plays a certain line, the line above the melody; and the tenor sax player would be playing the line below the melody, so you don't get in each other's way. But it's kind of a fun thing to do. I have a keyboard background, so that helps me a great deal as far as knowing harmony.

MR: In the typical society orchestra, I would imagine that professionalism was really important also, that you had to learn to be on time, to look right.

GM: Exactly. Take care of business. I mean you'd get there at least a half hour before the job starts, and just get on the stand and do what's expected. You know, the griping, if you have to play a cha cha, play a good one. If you don't like doing that stuff, don't take the job.

MR: Yeah, right. Well music, like you said, if it's good, if it's played well, if it's played in tune, you don't have to have it, that it's the greatest thing in the world, that it's my particular taste, but if you do it well it can still be enjoyable I would guess.

GM: That's the way I feel about it. I also did studio work when I was there too.

MR: Is this T.V. work?

GM: Some T.V. work, some television jingles and radio jingles and I did some writing and some recording, just for jazz companies, The Famous Door label.

MR: I see you've been with a number of different labels, The Famous Door and Dream Street and we'll talk about Arbors in a minute. Did you write any jingles?

GM: I did. Yes, I wrote some jingles for a company that was home based in Hartford, but they would come into New York. And I enjoyed that. First of all I found out I could do it. But I think it's kind of a nice, gratifying thing when they'll say this is the product and this is the slogan that we have that we want emphasized. So they would leave me alone and I would come up with something, and I was fortunate in that they were accepted.

MR: That's a tough assignment sometimes. You know, like here we're going to sing about a furniture company, you know? And what kind of music goes with a furniture company?

GM: I don't know if I would approach it that way. The thing to do is to get some kind of a melody that's simple enough so that people can hear it. They can hum it and they recognize it. And that you can put the words that they want emphasized to. So I think that's a help. When they say this is what we want. Let's see, one-stop shopping or something like that, instant banker, whatever. So that, right again, instant banker might suggest some kind of a motif with which you can start.

MR: Did you ever have to go back to the drawing board with any of your clients, that you thought, yeah this is going to work, and then the ad agency would say well—

GM: No I didn't, Monk, but I wasn't in it that long. You know, this company that I was working for, unfortunately went under and I didn't feel like I wanted to knock on doors and get trapped into a situation where I couldn't do the other things that I was doing, you know, some of the touring, the jazz festivals, and so forth.

MR: Well you know we kind of skipped over some early influences. You mentioned that your father was a musician and had a family orientation there with the music. The trombone players — I think I read that Cutty Cutshall and Lou McGarity were people that you aspired to.

GM: Lou was responsible for me playing trombone. I just heard his recording of "Yours" with the Benny Goodman Orchestra, I think it was 1941 or '42. He played an eight bar solo there, and I heard it and I said that's what I want to play.

MR: Eight bars and you knew what you wanted to do. That's saying something.

GM: It was such a driving force but so musical. And from that point on I got all the Goodman sextet records with Lou and learned all his choruses note for note, which is a great way to start I think. Eventually we all hope that we can be ourselves. And we have something that identifies us. But to begin with, you've got to hear something you like and you've got to hear a style that you like. Plus there were so many great players in those days, you know there was Jack Teagarden and Cutty Cutshall and Bill Harris and Jack Jenny and Trummy Young. I mean I had all these great players to listen to. It was a wonderful time to grow up.

MR: The swing music of that era, it was the pop music of the day. Is that correct?

GM: Exactly. My mother or father went and turned the radio on, and that's what we heard. Wasn't I lucky?

MR: Yeah. And I look at some of the books back from then and some of the magazine things, and they actually had fan clubs for the bands, just like rock & roll today. And they knew who was playing with who.

GM: Oh *Down Beat* magazine was a must with all of us. It had all the personnel changes, where the bands were playing, and reviewing recordings.

MR: It must have been a marvelous era, at least for that. When we look back on that time, I suppose we kind of romanticize about eras. I personally was not, I often think that I would have enjoyed playing music in that era. Was there things about that time that weren't so great? I mean of course you had World War II.

GM: Yeah, but World War II brought a lot of beautiful music. Look at all those beautiful ballads that came out of that — "White Cliffs of Dover," and "A Nightingale Sang in Berkley Square" and "Beware My Foolish Heart." Not only that but there were songs that had more to do with "Just Kissed Your Picture Goodnight," and had to do with the war, and people being separated but looking forward to when the lover would return from the service.

MR: Right. Romance took on a whole different meaning.

GM: Yeah. "Don't Sit Under The Apple Tree." Well you asked me if there were some downers at that — I don't remember exactly how you put it now.

MR: Well the things about living through the war years, that maybe I'm not aware of, that just were tougher. Let's say medicine, anything in particular?

GM: I don't remember anything in particular about medicine but you might be right. There was gas rationing going on then which curtailed a lot of traveling, and people weren't into traveling as much as they were today. There was a lot of defense work going on, and as far as music is concerned, there was a tremendous amount of activity with all the USO clubs. In fact that's where my father really got his start, during World War II there was such a demand for the kind of music that he was playing. And also for jazz, because entertainment became such a necessity in that time, because as you say there was so many negative aspects of it.

MR: People took a lot of comfort in the music then.

GM: Yes.

MR: And the dancing was so much a part of what went on.

GM: Oh, you know, they were almost inseparable, dancing and jazz music, or whatever you want to call it, swing music. You know, the Glenn Miller band, all of his arrangements were geared for the dance, for the ballroom. All of those bands in 1942, 3, 4 – look at

Benny Goodman. Even the ballads that he did, you know he would never play a ballad too slowly. He would give it a nice dance tempo.

MR: So even if people weren't dancing, they could think about it.

GM: That's true. In those days it was wonderful because, you know I was with the Jimmy Dorsey band in 1949 — '48, which was the tail end of the big band era, but there were still a lot of people who were into big bands. And it was great because a lot of them would just hang around the bandstand, to sit and listen and watch. A captive audience.

MR: Jimmy Dorsey was known for his breath control?

GM: That's Tommy.

MR: Tommy, sorry, Tommy.

GM: Marvelous breath control, you know, as a trombonist, he was one of my inspirations too, I should have mentioned him earlier, but he was such a great ballad player you know. And he had such control, I mean he could play right up in front of the microphone, very, very softly and let the microphone do a lot of work. But he had great control and beautiful sound.

MR: Was he a good guy to work for?

GM: Well I was with Jimmy. So Jimmy was a nice person to work for. Great musician too. I think unfortunately he lived in the shadow of Tommy, but he was a marvelous clarinet and saxophonist.

MR: Gee some of the stuff he recorded back then was, from a technical standpoint, with all that double tonguing and all that, that was hard to reproduce.

GM: Highly proficient technically. But he also had a lot in here. Sometimes he would play ballads, particularly on alto, and it would bring tears to your eyes. He was a good improviser too. I don't think a lot of people realize this.

MR: As a matter of fact, the Jimmy Dorsey Orchestra just played at Hamilton a couple of weeks ago.

GM: Oh really?

MR: I forget the fellow — the fellow who's leading it now is a trombone player.

GM: Yes. I met him recently, I can't recall his name. But I do some things with the Artie Shaw band, led by Dick Johnson, who is a very close friend of mine, and we live in the same area. So I go out with him occasionally and do things. And once place we were playing they had two bands, the other band was the Jimmy Dorsey band.

MR: Right now in your career, do you pick and choose what you want to do a little more than before?

GM: Yes. I'm happy to say I do. But there isn't a lot to refuse you know? I mean most of the calls that I get, and almost everybody in this business is dealing over the telephone, you

know you get calls and you're invited to various festivals or you're invited to join a tour. But most of them are calls that I'm happy to receive and accept.

MR: These jazz parties are an interesting little phenomenon in the country and I hope they continue.

GM: I do too. It's a nice concept. I think Dick Gibson started this years ago in Colorado, and a lot of other jazz societies around the country decided that they would take a weekend and call it either a jazz festival or a jazz party. And incidentally, this one here at the Jerome is just superb. It starts with a party and ends with a party.

MR: Yeah. Nice surroundings too.

GM: Yes indeed.

MR: Yeah. I was going to play a little something for you, and get your comment on this. [audio interlude]

MR: I assume you recognize that.

GM: I sure do.

MR: Your latest? Is this your latest recording?

GM: No, it's not. No. This is the one with Dan Barrett?

MR: Dan Barrett, yeah.

GM: Yeah. "Let's Be Buddies."

MR: Yeah.

GM: I have one that was just released, and I call it "That Old Gang of Mine." It's on Arbors. And it's all players from the southern New England area that I grew up with, with the exception of Marshall Wood, the bassist, but he's such a good player, he had to be on it. I've known Marshall at least ten years. But the other guys I've known for about 40 years and I've been wanting to do this. It's Dick Johnson, Lou Columbo — are you familiar with that name? Dave McKenna, Marshall Wood, Artie Cabral, a drummer from Providence, and myself. It's a sextet. And it really is, it's that old gang of mine, and I was just so happy that Arbors let me do it, and in fact they got behind me a hundred percent and just gave me carte blanche.

MR: Wow. That's a good label. I mean they really are supporting this kind of music, whatever it is.

GM: Who knows? Why do we have to name it?

MR: I know. Isn't that something? But this particular tune, "Melancholy Baby," what made you think of doing it, as a sort of samba?

GM: It's a beautiful tune. And I just, I do love to do things as a bossa nova, and I'm constantly thinking of what tune might be good in that context. And "Melancholy Baby," I thought I would give it a try. I play the verse on that too, which is really beautiful.

MR: Yeah. When it first started out I'm going, this isn't the "Melancholy Baby" I know. I don't think I ever heard the verse before.

GM: A lot of people haven't.

MR: Of course we always associate that tune with the drunken request I think.

GM: I know.

MR: But actually no one ever asked me for that.

GM: I haven't had that experience either, but the joke is as old as the hills.

MR: Right, right. Oh, my. What's in the future for you?

GM: Next Thursday I will leave for the United Kingdom, and I'll do a two and a half week tour there — Scotland, England and one night in Germany. And then I will finish that tour with five days in Vienna, and it will be a three and a half week tour all told.

MR: You are going by yourself?

GM: I'm going by myself. I'll be doing some dates in England with Harry Allen. He and I and a rhythm section. In fact, I think we're going to be making a CD while we're there for Nagal-Hayer records, it's a German company and they're doing quite well. And as I say I'll finish up in Vienna. So that's what's in store for me within the next month.

MR: That's great. Are your children musical?

GM: Yes. They all played in high school. Our son, who is the oldest, is a good trombonist but he's into other things and it's an avocation for him, and he will play with a big band every now and then. And our youngest daughter is a flutist, sometime they say flautist, I don't know why, anyway, good flute player. And she's raising two children and she doesn't have much time for it now, but she's starting to do some playing with her husband who is a choir director, and he's a musical director for a local church, and she's starting to do some. She's a good performer and I think she'll get into chamber performing eventually, when the children get older.

MR: I've seen in colleges and high schools that trombone players are getting a bit scarce. Have you seen that?

GM: Yeah. I guess it's true. I hear a lot about it, but I also hear about young trombone players coming up — very, very good players too. A case in point is John Allred, who is here at this festival. Excellent player with a lot of facility and he knows how to make music with it too.

MR: Yeah?

GM: Yeah. Dan Barrett is a colleague and a good friend and a marvelous player. I love playing with Dan because we work well off one another. And I mean there are even younger guys coming up out of the colleges who have a tremendous amount of facility and range. You know the instrument has changed so much over the last 30 or 40 years in that you know people like Carl Fontana and Bill Watrous and Urbie Green had such facility and inspired

an awful lot of these younger people I think to develop it. It's a whole different approach to playing you know. I think the microphone becomes an extension of your instrument — a different approach. But I have a lot of respect for these guys that developed that.

MR: Did you ever see the book *Jazz Anecdotes*?

GM: Yes, I've seen it, I know Bill Crow very well. I just spoke with Bill on the phone two days ago. What a wonderful writer, and what a great musician, a wonderful bassist. And there's some great stories in there, and they're all true.

MR: He included one that you're in. With Vic Dickinson? Do you recall that?

GM: I think so. We were rehearsing with the big band. Vic just had me on the floor—

MR: Tell me about that.

GM: —without even trying. Well we were playing this particular Hoagy Carmichael tune. It was a Hoagy Carmichael concert. And Dick Sudhalter was leading the band, and he didn't like the way it ended. There was an ending, and he thought well you know, let's hold it all out, let's hold the ending, and we put a fermata over it, you know this line that means you hold it until you're cut off. So everybody marks a fermata , but Vic doesn't mark the spot or anything, he's just sitting there. So we try it with the fermata , and Dick didn't like it. "You know," he said," "I think we'll just play it the way it is, it's a quarter note and we'll cut it short. Let's try it that way." And we go back eight bars from the end and we try it, and played it with a quarter note, and Dick said "I'm not sure." Everybody erased the fermata you know. And then he said, "You know what, let's hold it three beats and we'll cut it off on the fourth beat." So we try it that way, and we hold it three beats, cut it off on the fourth beat, and Dick said, "Yeah, that's the way we'll do it." I said to Vic, "Vic, do you want me to mark your part?" He says, "No, George, I wasn't going to hold it very long anyway." And that was typical of Vic, you know what I mean? We just played that the way he felt like.

MR: It sounded like he was a little tired from a lot of road work over the years.

GM: Well he was so laid back anyways, that was his nature.

MR: It was his personality. If you were to design a course, a jazz history course, would there be things that you would emphasize? You mentioned active listening. Maybe that's more my question. What does active listening mean to you?

GM: Well I guess it means listening and making judgments as you go along on what you like — say oh listen to that chorus, listen to what Lester does in this particular phrase, or gee, I don't know why so and so did that. Listening to the music for what's inside of it. As far as jazz history, I really don't feel competent to be able to get into that because I'm as guilty as a lot of other musicians in that when I started to play, that's where I started to listen. I didn't go back. I didn't listen to Louis Armstrong until years later. And I should

have when I first started to play. He had so much to say and so many of those player, Bix Beiderbecke and players in the early twenties.

MR: I think that's usually the case, and then sometimes hopefully people's tastes will, or at least their listening habits will work backwards to see what went on before. And of course now with the young players, they're starting with Kenny G and Grover Washington and those kind of players, and getting their jazz from that. They have a lot farther to work backwards I guess.

GM: They do. And I certainly hope that somebody will make it imperative that they do it. But you know people who are designing these History of Jazz classes really should have a listening list and a required listening list, and demand some feedback from the listening.

MR: Well it's been quite enjoyable talking to you.

GM: I enjoyed it too, Monk.

MR: Have any words of wisdom for any aspiring jazz musicians these days?

GM: All I can say is if you're learning — aspiring jazz? You mean players who already have the ability and would like to get out into the field?

MR: Yeah.

GM: It's a tough field, and I would say try to learn how to cover as many bases as you can. You know it's one thing to be a jazz player and to excel in this idiom, but also you really have to know how to read music and if you're going to try to make a living at it, you may have to do other things than just play jazz. So learn how to be a craftsman as well as an artist.

MR: Yeah. That's good advice.

GM: And I wouldn't hesitate to do a society job, but I wouldn't want to do it with people who are not really competent. The reason I say that is because it puts money on the table, and that's a necessity. But it only should be done if you're going to play with good musicians — guys who want to do it right.

MR: Right. You know I think there's a great deal of pleasure — it took me a while to figure out when I was playing for folks that were older than me, when I was playing certain kinds of dance numbers. And I noticed when I wasn't getting them, and I'd change the tempo until I got the right tempo, and then they'd get up and dance, you know? Or sometimes they'd get up and dance and try what you were — and they'd sit down again. I'd go, wait a minute — it's not because I played a wrong note. That's not why they sat down.

GM: That is so important. I mean that's a knack in itself, you know how people can just observe what the crowd is responding to and know how to do what they're supposed to do. I mean when you're hired for that kind of work I think the success or failure of that function depends really on the person who is furnishing the music.

MR: Well that sounds like an up note to end on, to me. So I'll be listening tonight. I hope you have a great rest of the weekend, and thank you for joining us.

GM: You're welcome. My pleasure.

MR: Okay.